

conversations that throw up Islamic terrorists, rigid religious beliefs, Pakistan and madrasas, the response is inevitably another set of questions—why has the Bajrang Dal not labelled a terrorist outfit, why the public display of festivals like Navratras not considered rigid religious beliefs, why should Muslims in India be answerable for what goes on in Pakistan, what spaces other than madrasas are available for thousands of believing Muslims who choose to get educated and still retain their Muslim-ness?

But how does one fight that when shared cultural spaces, other than those created by the market, shrink? How does one speak of the diversity of being Indian when Diwali is celebrated in schools and Id just in Muslim homes? How does one avoid a singular label for experiences that are diverse and yet have a common thread—the experience of a tailor in Ahmedabad whose Hindu patrons have stopped giving work to him, the butcher in Batla House who couldn't get a bank

SIPRA DAS



“I MAY ESCAPE THE CAULDRON FOR ISLAMIC TERRORISTS BUT THEN I WILL BE PUT INTO THE ONE FOR MISGUIDED INTELLECTUALS.”

loan, the software professional who will now watch every single byte that leaves his computer.

Being Muslim in India today means many things to many people. But how easy it is to forget that one fundamental reality. How easy it is to say, as someone said to me after the Delhi blasts: “These are all educated Muslims. Don't they know that their bombs can also kill their own?” As if anyone with a Muslim name is a terrorist's very “own”.



MUKHTAR ABBAS NAQVI

BJP leader

Thanks to votebank politics, anybody with a skull cap and a beard is treated as the product of Osama's terror factory

Thanks to the atmosphere of suspicion created by votebank politics, anybody with a beard and a skull cap is treated as the product of Osama bin Laden's terror factory.

Thanks to the mishandling of several cases and attitude of the administration, Muslims by and large find themselves at the receiving end—in a position similar to that of the Sikhs in the mid-1980s. In the past, Muslims were arrested even in cases of petty crimes, but now they are being branded as terrorists. Terrorism in India is aimed at creating a fear psychosis among Muslims, to shake their confidence. This is because the merchants of Muslim votes feel that if they are terrorised and demoralised, they would naturally come to them for protection and in the bargain, vote for them. Remember when the roots of Al Qaida were being searched in the aftermath of 9/11, India was free from terrorism. L.K. Advani, the then deputy prime minister, had stated that our country was free from this deadly disease. But now how and why does everyone find terrorism everywhere in India?

Likewise, if saner elements and intellectuals are speaking against state terrorism, they should not be criticised or attacked. Remember when Sikhs were being projected as killers (of Indira Gandhi) and terrorists (in Punjab), Khushwant Singh stood up against the persecution of the community. The Government at the Centre and its agencies are competing against each other to count the number of terrorists killed or captured without realising that by doing so, directly or indirectly, they are encouraging and strengthening terrorism.

The society should play a positive role and should display positive attitude. This alone would help create a healthy atmosphere and end terrorism.

As told to Farzand Ahmed